Getting Ready for a Medicaid Readiness Review

Your family's part, in order: eleven actions, with a line for who does each and by when.

The goal: you can hand a professional a dated picture of where Mom stands today, what your family doesn't know yet, and the questions you'd like answered.

Nothing about Mom's situation is pressing, so take this a little at a time. Share the list, put a name next to each action, add a date if that helps, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Write down the state Mom lives in and roughly how long she has lived there, and whether she is married. If she is, include her spouse in the lists that follow.			
2. Note what she does on her own today and any help she already gets, as what you've seen.			
3. List each source of her income and how it arrives.			
4. List her accounts, investments and other property, with how you know each one. Don't sort them into what counts and what doesn't, and don't add them up.			
5. Find the deed to her home. Write down whose name is on it and whether there is a mortgage or other loan.			
6. List any retirement accounts, life insurance policies and annuities, with the company and where the paperwork is.			
7. Note anything she owns jointly with someone else, and whether there is a trust. “Nobody is sure” is a fine answer.			
8. List any significant gifts, transfers or ownership changes in recent years: what, roughly when, who was involved, and what paperwork exists.			
9. Write down your questions, and next to each the kind of professional you'd ask: your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney or a licensed financial professional.			
10. Put it on one dated page: where things stand today, what you don't know, and your questions.			
11. Agree on the changes that would prompt another look: in her health or care needs, her finances or her marital status.			

You're done when

Where Mom stands today is written down with a date on it, the things your family doesn't know are showing as blanks, and each question has the kind of professional beside it. What comes after that isn't on this list: comparing her situation with her state's rules, saying what could affect eligibility, and working out whether anything is worth looking at ahead of time. That part isn't the family's to do alone.

If it slows down

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “We don't know yet” is a finished line.
- If Mom would rather not go through part of it, leave that part. It's her information, and the page is still useful with a blank on it.
- If someone has an idea along the way, such as a gift or a new name on an account, write it under action 9 as a question for a professional.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's part. It doesn't determine whether Mom would qualify for Medicaid, compare anything with a limit, or stand in for the readiness review it prepares you for. Rules vary by state. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've worked through your family's part, a little at a time, and you know where it stops. The planning interview is the next step: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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